

18TH-CENTURY SWORDS

Through the 1700s, the sword was becoming less important as an infantry weapon, although it was still valued by the heavy and light cavalry, and also often fulfilled a ceremonial role. In China, it accounted for two out of the four main weapons – the staff, the spear, the singled-edged *dao* sword, and the double-edged *jian* sword. Tibetans, too, had a tradition of sword manufacture, with designs that were similar to Chinese models. Swordsmiths of the Ottoman Empire, established by Turks who migrated from central Asia to Anatolia, favoured a curved blade derived from the Turko-Mongolian sabre of the 13th century.

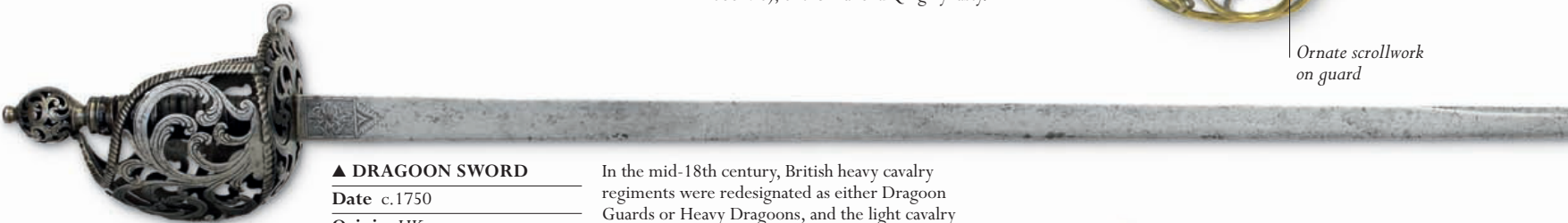


▲ CHINESE JIAN
Date 1735–1796
Origin China
Weight 1.25kg (2¾lb)
Length 1.07m (3½ft)

Chinese swordsmen chose the straight, double-edged *jian* sword to show off their skills. This sword dates from the reign of Emperor Qianlong (ruled 1735–96), of the Manchu Qing dynasty.



Ornate scrollwork on guard



▲ DRAGOON SWORD
Date c.1750
Origin UK
Weight 1.15kg (2½lb)
Length 1.13m (3¾ft)

In the mid-18th century, British heavy cavalry regiments were redesignated as either Dragoon Guards or Heavy Dragoons, and the light cavalry as Light Dragoons. Long, single-edged swords were used by both divisions of heavy cavalry through the 18th century and into the Napoleonic era.



Basket hilt to protect knuckles

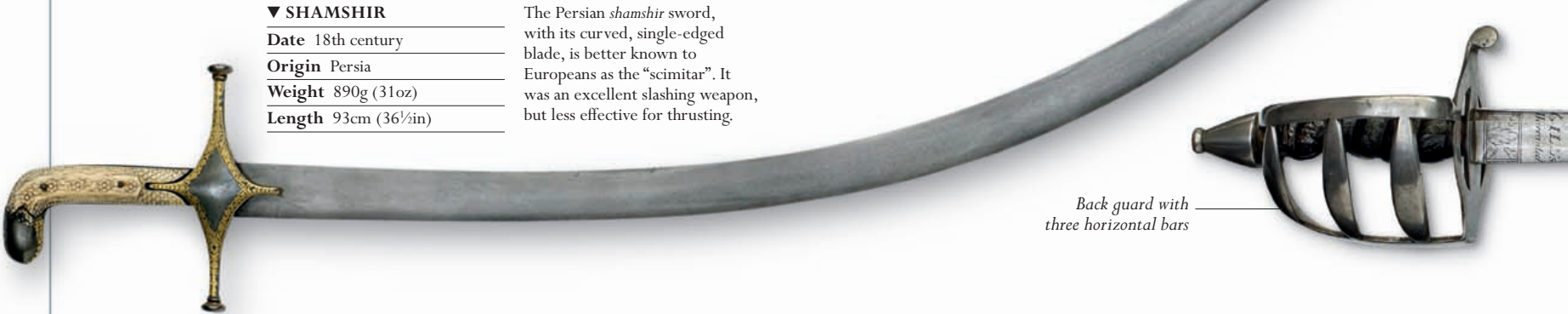


▲ CAVALRY OFFICERS' SWORD
Date 1730
Origin UK
Weight 1.6kg (3½lb)
Length 86cm (33¾in)

This English cavalry officers' sword has a highly ornate, decorated, gilt-brass basket hilt. The blade is inscribed with the royal monogram "GR" – King George II – beneath a crown.



Ornate pommel



▼ SHAMSHIR
Date 18th century
Origin Persia
Weight 890g (31oz)
Length 93cm (36½in)

The Persian *shamshir* sword, with its curved, single-edged blade, is better known to Europeans as the "scimitar". It was an excellent slashing weapon, but less effective for thrusting.



Back guard with three horizontal bars